

Number and gender

PRONOUNS AND DETERMINERS MUST AGREE WITH THE NOUNS TO WHICH THEY RELATE.

In English, there are no personal pronouns or possessive determiners that can be used to refer to someone without identifying whether that person is male or female. This often results in mismatched combinations of singular nouns and plural pronouns or determiners.

Matching numbers

Pronouns must agree in number (singular or plural) with the nouns they represent. Plural nouns or pronouns must be followed by plural pronouns or determiners, and singular nouns or pronouns must be followed by singular pronouns or determiners.

Pronoun	Determiner
I	my
you	your
he	his
she	her
it	its
we	our
you	your
they	their

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• If a piece of text is likely to become clumsy with the repetition of **his** or **her**, try using certain nouns in the plural form to add **variety**.

GLOSSARY

Indefinite pronoun A pronoun such as *everyone* that refers to nobody or nothing specific.

Number The term used to identify a noun or pronoun as singular or plural.

Personal pronoun A pronoun that takes the place of a noun and represents people, places, or things.

Possessive determiner A word that is used before a noun to show ownership.

They were preparing for **their** told **his** students that **everyone**

• When using the word **each**, think about “**each one**,” as it makes it easier to remember that **each** is always followed by a **singular pronoun** or **determiner**.

• Some words, such as **each** and **all**, are used both as **determiners** and as **pronouns**. Remember that a determiner is always used in front of a noun, whereas a pronoun replaces a noun.

Indefinite pronouns

Indefinite pronouns such as *everyone* and *anything* often cause problems. Although they appear to refer to more than one person or thing, these pronouns are, in fact, singular words. One way of establishing whether a pronoun is singular or plural is to put the verb form *are* right after it. If the resulting combination sounds wrong, then that pronoun is singular.

Singular	Plural
everyone is	both are
somebody is	all are
something is	many are
each is	most are
nothing is	others are
another is	few are